

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD X

2001-119

**Species:** Black Scoter (*Melanitta nigra*)**Date:** 12 November 2001**Number seen:** one**Sex:** ?**Plumage:** ?**Locality:** Blue Mesa Res.**Elevation:** about 7510'**Nearest town:** Gunnison**County:** Gunnison**Time observed:** ~1030-1050 MST**Duration of observation:** off and on for about 8 minutes during that time

Description: While scanning through the goldeneyes (mostly Barrow's) just to the west of the Hwy 149 bridge over Blue Mesa Res., one of my birding compadres, Brian, beat me to the last bird in the flock and yelled out, "Black Scoter." I quickly finished scanning through the last couple birds and wholeheartedly agreed with him, as I was looking at an adult female Black Scoter. We studied it and Brian videotaped it for a bit and then continued south on Hwy 149. At a pulloff south of the bridge, we again studied the bird and videotaped it. The combination of plumage features (bright face patch, all-dark belly) was somewhat puzzling, so I am unsure of the age and sex of the bird.

The bird was a medium-sized diving duck that was a bit larger than the goldeneyes. It was dark brownish-black with a paler whitish face. This pale patch was accentuated by a very black crown and dark brown nape. It had an all-black bill that was fairly small for a scoter. The crown and back of the neck were blackish and contrasted fairly strongly with the paler face. The paler color of the face extended onto the throat where it ended abruptly. The head was round, unlike the long, slanted heads of the other two species of scoter. As it dove a couple times, I could discern that the belly was a paler brown than was most of the rest of the body, but there was no white there. The tail was blackish and held along the water's surface. The legs were dark.

Similar species eliminated: Both other scoter species are eliminated by size, bill size, and head shape and pattern (face all the same color - no whiter spots anywhere). Ruddy Duck female eliminated by lack of dark eyeline; all Ruddy Ducks eliminated by size, head shape, coloration, and tail posture. Other female diving ducks by head pattern and lack of back/side color contrast. Male Gadwall eliminated by plumage pattern. Female Gadwall eliminated by diving behavior and lack of strong brown in the plumage.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): No vocalizations heard.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen 10s of 1000s each of all three scoter species. I have also seen large numbers of all confusable species.

Light conditions: sun variably behind me and behind me to my left

Optical equipment used: Swarovski 8.5x42 and Leica 32x

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest approach of about 20 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Brian Gibbons, Nancy Gobris

Other observers who saw the bird independently: Rich Levad, at least

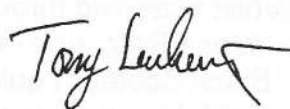
If photographed, type of equipment and film: I did not photograph; Brian videotaped it

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none **b) after observation:** none

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature:



Address: Rocky Mountain Bird Observatory, 14500 Lark Bunting Lane, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: 9 December 2001 from notes written on the evening of the sighting